CINEMA ▼

LOVE STORY WITH A TWIST

BEJOY NAMBIAR'S *TU YAA MAIN* IS THE LATEST IN A LONG LINE OF CREATURE FEATURES, A GENRE WHOSE APPEAL SEEMS TO BE EVERLASTING

Two Gen Z influencers (Shanaya Kapoor and Adarsh Gourav) get stuck in a pool with a crocodile and try their best to stay alive. *Tu Yaa Main* (*TYM*), Bejoy Nambiar's survival thriller and creature feature—a *desi* adaptation of the Thai film *The Pool*—aims for cheap thrills by testing the relationship of a young couple. "They say when you're pushed into a corner, the choices you make show your true character," he says.

For Nambiar, the film is also a way to deep dive into the creator economy. "One phone and they are able to reach great heights," he says. "It's also how democratised the platform is." Here, the medium facilitates a love story between a lifestyle and a rapper creator who come from disparate socio-economic backgrounds. Adds Nambiar, "I wanted to make sure these two worlds collide in an authentic way and to make it believable."

Another aspect that needed to be compelling was the creature itself. Trying to keep visual effects to the minimum, Nambiar was insistent they rope in a real crocodile to generate the shrieks. Luckily for him, his line producer found the baddie at a crocodile farm in Bangkok. Fondly named Dhanno by the crew, the croc, according to Nambiar, "was the best actor", delivering more than what they asked for. Filling in for Dhanno on set in India was Gudiya, the animatronics ava-

The film, directed by Bejoy Nambiar (right), follows a couple—played by Shanaya Kapoor and Adarsh Gourav (below)—whose date goes awry when they encounter a crocodile



